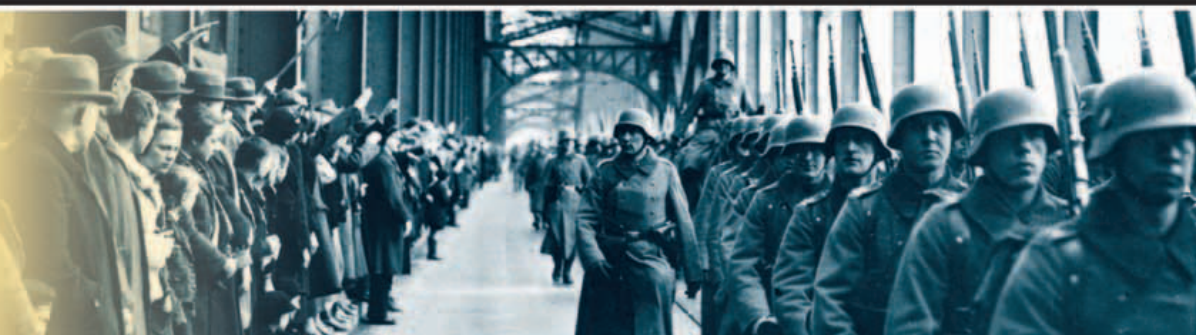


22 THOUSAND THE NUMBER OF GERMAN TROOPS THAT MARCHED INTO RHINELAND



German troops march across a bridge into the demilitarized Rhineland. Hitler feared a military response by the Western democracies that never came.

EUROPE HAD BEGUN TO SLIDE

inexorably down the slope toward a **major war**. On March 7, Hitler sent troops into the Rhineland, a part of Germany that had been demilitarized under the terms of the Locarno Pact (see 1925). The operation was perfectly stage-managed, the marching soldiers greeted by cheering crowds and women throwing flowers. However, behind the scenes Hitler and his generals were racked by nervous tension. **German rearmament** was still in its early stages and the German army could not have resisted if France had opted for a military response, but strong public opinion and domestic issues inhibited a stronger stand. By doing nothing, the Western allies showed they would not act to uphold international agreements.

The **British and French** nonetheless embarked on **expansion of their armed forces** in response to developments in Germany. In Britain, Conservative leader Stanley Baldwin had won a general election in 1935 partly due to his promise to limit rearmament. Despite having a mandate for military expansion, Baldwin continued to proceed cautiously.

The main focus was on achieving an effective defense of Britain against attack by the **German Luftwaffe** (air force). Two days before Hitler's occupation of the Rhineland, a new fighter aircraft, the **Supermarine Spitfire**, made its maiden flight. RAF Fighter Command was created on May 1, responsible for air defense. It was



to be equipped with the Spitfire and the Hawker Hurricane, also then under development.

The importance of air power was demonstrated in the **conquest of Ethiopia** by Fascist Italy (see 1935). Italian aircraft were used to deliver poison gas onto Ethiopian troops, contributing to the defeat of Emperor Haile Selassie and the

occupation of Addis Ababa in May. **Selassie fled to exile** in Britain.

The following month he made a memorable speech at the League of Nations, ending with the ominous prophecy: "It is us today; it will be you tomorrow."

Confronted with the successes of Fascism and Naziism, the Soviet-controlled **Comintern**

Workers unite

Armed workers trample on Nazi and Fascist symbols in this Spanish Civil War poster. Communists were initially a minority in the Republican camp.

(Communist International) had decided that communist parties should seek to form "**Popular Front**" alliances with social democrat and center parties. This policy bore fruit in France in May, when the Popular Front, led by socialist **Léon Blum**, won a large majority in parliamentary elections. At the same time, a workers' strike had led to the occupation of factories and department stores across France. Blum's first act as prime minister was to settle the strike by negotiating the **Matignon agreements**, which gave workers improved conditions including a 40-hour week and paid vacations. Struggling to maintain the support of communists on one side and centrist radicals on the other, however, the Blum government was soon bogged down in economic problems and the diplomatic dilemma posed by the outbreak of civil war in Spain.

A Popular Front of communists, socialists, republicans, and

anarchists won Spanish elections

in February. The Popular Front government promised sweeping land reforms and autonomy for **Catalonia**, but events soon ran out of their control, with peasants seizing large estates and anti-clerical attacks on convents and churches. On July 13, José Calvo Sotelo, a leading anti-Popular Front politician, was murdered by socialist militants. Four days later, **Nationalist army** officers based in Spanish Morocco launched a **military uprising**. Resisted by hastily armed socialist and anarchist militias, and a large proportion of the Spanish armed forces, the revolt failed across much of Spain—Madrid, the Basque country, and Catalonia remained in Republican hands. When German and Italian aircraft began to ferry General Francisco Franco's **Army of Africa** from Morocco into southern Spain, the military revolt turned into civil war.

At first, a rapid Nationalist victory appeared probable. While Germany and Italy provided men, tanks, and aircraft to support the rebels, France and Britain adopted

The Spanish Civil War

Crossing from Spanish Morocco, Nationalist troops advanced north. The Republicans held on to Madrid in desperate fighting.

KEY

- Republican zone
- Nationalist gains
- Initial Nationalist zone



January 6 US Supreme Court rules **New Deal** Agricultural Adjustment Act **unconstitutional**

January 22 French prime minister Pierre Laval resigns in fall-out from **Hoare-Laval Pact** of 1934

January 20 British King George V (b.1865) dies, succeeded by Edward VIII

February 16 Left-wing **Popular Front** coalition wins Spanish general election

February 8 Jawaharlal Nehru elected leader of **Indian National Congress**

March 5 British **Supermarine Spitfire** fighter aircraft makes maiden flight

February 26 Military rebellion in Japan fails but leading politicians killed

April 19 Arab Revolt begins in Palestine, protesting against British rule and Jewish immigration

March 7 German troops march into demilitarized Rhineland

May 3 Parties of the left make large advances in **French** parliamentary elections

May 9 Italy annexes **Ethiopia**

June 4 Popular Front government established in France with **Léon Blum** as prime minister

May 26 General strike begins in France

June 7 **Matignon** Agreements end French general strike, leading to major improvements in **workers' conditions**

June 30 **Haile Selassie**, in exile, addresses League of Nations